A FREE CASE FROM ASHCOMBE MANOR

The Answer: A Friday at Ashcombe

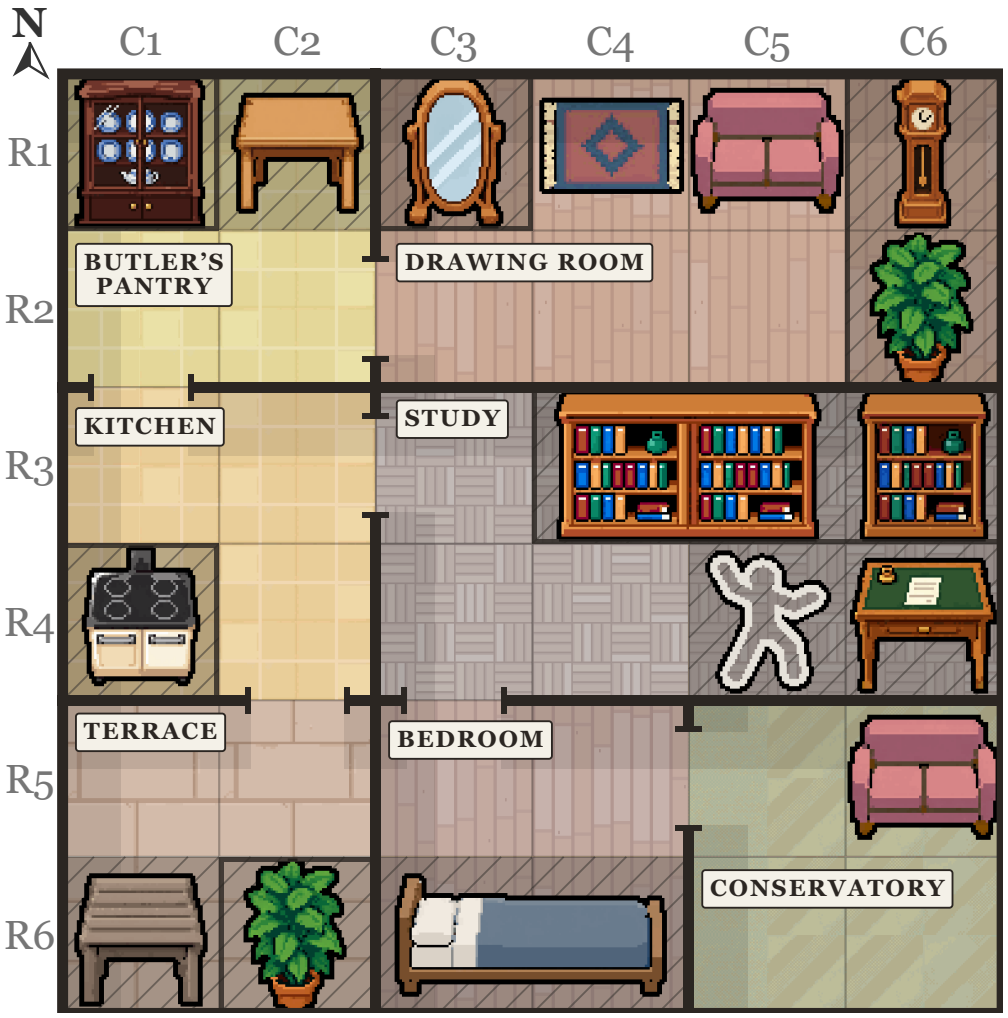
Here is the case again, and then its answer one deduction at a time, with a picture of the plan after each step. In the pictures, **yellow** squares are where the suspect in question could still be, **red crosses** are what that step has just ruled out, and **initials** mark suspects already placed.

FREE CASE

A Friday at Ashcombe

GENTLE

SOLVED STEP BY STEP ON THE FOLLOWING PAGES



Seven o'clock on a Friday, and the gates of Ashcombe Manor were locked. Miss Pell dealt the cards in silence, the lamps went out for one minute, and when they came back on, Sam lay in the Study.

THE CLUES

1. Agatha was beside a china cabinet.
2. Douglas was beside a bed.
3. Nora was beside the couch in the Conservatory.
4. Jack was in the third row.
5. Clara was not beside a stove.
6. Edith was not in a corner.

GENERAL CLUES

7. The person in the third column wore no monocle.

THE SUSPECTS



1. Jack
a fedora
a beard



2. Douglas
a monocle
a beard



3. Agatha
a fedora
spectacles



4. Clara
a bowler
spectacles



5. Edith
a fedora
a monocle

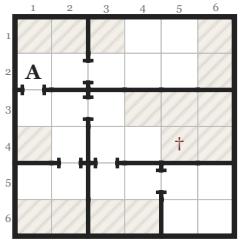


6. Nora
a fedora
a monocle

THE MURDERER

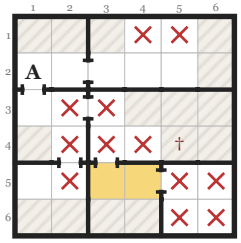
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The answer, step by step



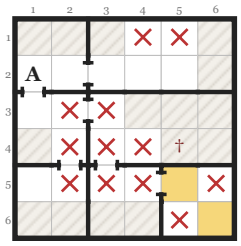
1 Clue 1 settles it: Agatha is at R2C1.

> **Reading a statement exactly.** Some statements name a square outright, or leave only one square the plan allows.

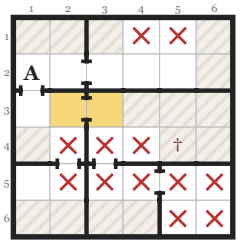


2 Clue 2: Douglas must be somewhere in row 5.

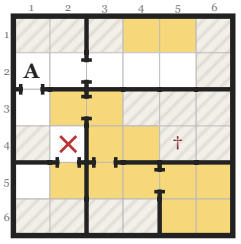
> **Ruling out.** A statement that says where a guest was not is still a statement: cross those squares off.



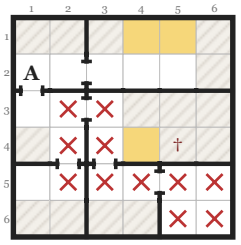
3 Clue 3: Nora must be in the Conservatory.



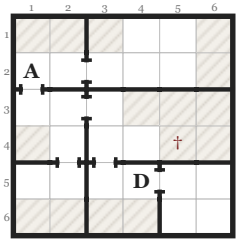
4 Clue 4: Jack must be somewhere in row 3.



5 Clue 5: Clara has 13 squares left.

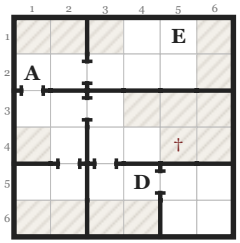


6 Clue 6: Edith must be at R1C4 or R1C5 or R4C4.



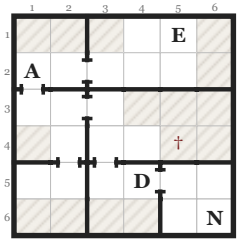
7 Clue 7 settles it: Douglas is at R5C4.

> **What they wore.** Statements about hats, spectacles, monocles and beards refer to the lineup. Work out who they can be about first, then where.

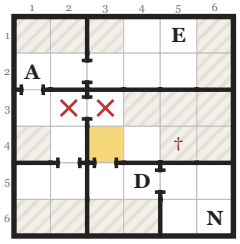


8 Edith has only one square left: R1C5.

> **One square left.** When everything else has been ruled out for a guest, the square that remains is theirs.

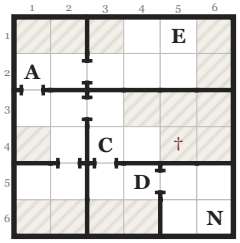


9 Nora has only one square left: R6C6.

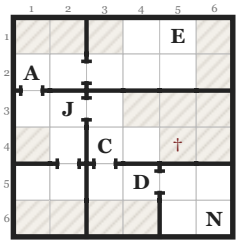


10 Clara is the only suspect who can still stand in row 4, so she must be somewhere in it.

> **The only one who fits.** Every row and column must hold exactly one guest. If only one guest can still stand anywhere in a line, they must stand there.



11 Clara has only one square left: R4C3.



12 Only one square is left for Jack, so Jack is at R3C2.

With the grid full, only Clara was in the Study with Sam. Clara is the murderer.

The next case

Every Friday, Miss Pell posts a new case at **whereaboutspuzzles.com**. Fifty more are in her ledger, **Whereabouts: Murder Sudoku — 50 Murder Mysteries from Ashcombe Manor**, from spring to winter.